

INTERNAL SECURITY PROTOCOL

OUTSMARTING DIGITAL DECEPTIONS

Phishing Awareness Training: Recognizing
Threats, Securing Data, and Protecting Our
Organization



ANATOMY OF A PHISHING EMAIL

● **From:** Microsoft Security <admin@micros0ft-alert.net>
To: employee@organization.com
Subject: **URGENT:** Your Account Access is Suspended

● Dear **Valued Customer**,

We have detected unusual sign-in activity on your Microsoft 365 account from an unrecognized device in Eastern Europe.

To prevent unauthorized access, your account has been **temporarily locked**. You must verify your identity within **2 hours** or your data will be permanently deleted.

Please click the secure link below to restore your access:

<https://portal.microsoft.com/auth/verify-account>

(Actual link: <http://bit.ly/secure-login-3921>)

Regards,
Microsoft Global Security Team

1. SENDER MISMATCH

The display name looks real, but the email address uses a look-alike domain (micros0ft).

2. GENERIC GREETING

Attackers use "Customer" or "User" because they don't know your actual name.

3. ARTIFICIAL URGENCY

Threats of account deletion or short deadlines are designed to bypass your logic.

4. LINK DECEPTION

The text says one thing, but the destination URL (hover to see) is completely different.

THE **RISING TIDE** OF CYBER CRIME



MASSIVE VOLUME

1M+

Phishing attacks logged per quarter in 2025. The frequency is increasing exponentially.



CRITICAL IMPACT

90%

Of all successful data breaches originate from a single, well-crafted phishing email.



AVERAGE COST

\$4.4M

The global average cost of a single breach. In the US, this figure exceeds \$10 million.

DON'T TRUST THE **DIGITAL MIRROR**

LEGITIMATE WEBSITE

 <https://microsoft.com/login>

Authentic domains are simple, clear, and verified.

TYPOSQUATTED FAKE

 <https://micros0ft-login.net>

Attackers use look-alike characters and extra keywords to deceive you.

THE PADLOCK MYTH

A "Secure" HTTPS padlock does **NOT** mean a website is safe. It only means the connection is encrypted.

80% of phishing sites now use HTTPS to appear trustworthy. The padlock protects your data in transit, but it doesn't tell you WHO is receiving it at the other end.

HACKING THE HUMAN BRAIN

PSYCHOLOGICAL WARFARE & SOCIAL ENGINEERING



AUTHORITY

Attackers impersonate high-ranking executives, IT admins, or legal authorities to bypass your natural skepticism.

THE EMOTIONAL TRIGGER:

Compliance & Deference



URGENCY

Creating a false sense of crisis forces victims to act quickly, bypassing the brain's logical reasoning centers.

THE EMOTIONAL TRIGGER:

Anxiety & Panic



FEAR & GREED

Exploiting basic survival instincts—the fear of a security breach or the desire for an unexpected financial reward.

THE EMOTIONAL TRIGGER:

Emotional Hijacking

THE **ATTACK SURFACE** IS EVERYWHERE



SMISHING

Fraudulent SMS messages designed to trick you into clicking malicious links or sharing personal data via your mobile device.

THE THREAT:

Fake delivery alerts or "urgent" bank notifications sent directly to your pocket.



VISHING

Voice phishing using phone calls to manipulate victims. Attackers often spoof caller IDs to look like trusted organizations.

THE THREAT:

Impersonating IT support or government agencies to steal credentials or MFA codes.



QUISHING

The use of malicious QR codes in emails or physical posters that redirect users to fraudulent login pages.

THE THREAT:

Bypassing email filters by hiding malicious URLs inside a visual code.

THE EVOLUTION OF DECEPTION: **AI PHISHING**



FLAWLESS LANGUAGE

Generative AI removes the **grammar and spelling errors** that once signaled fraud. Phishing emails now look perfectly professional in any language.

HYPER-PERSONALIZATION

AI tools scrape social media and corporate sites to craft **highly tailored lures** that reference your specific projects, colleagues, and interests.

DEEPPAKE MEDIA

Attackers can now use **AI-generated voice and video** to impersonate executives in real-time during phone calls or virtual meetings.

LESSONS FROM HIGH-PROFILE BREACHES



GOOGLE & FACEBOOK

THE VECTOR

Evaldas Rimasauskas used fake invoices and look-alike corporate identities to trick finance teams.

THE IMPACT

Over two years, the tech giants transferred massive sums to fraudulent accounts.

\$100M+ LOST



SONY PICTURES

THE VECTOR

Executives were targeted with fake "Apple" security alerts, leading to credential theft.

THE IMPACT

Massive leak of private emails, salaries, and unreleased films. Total reputational collapse.

\$100M+ DAMAGE



TWITTER (2020)

THE VECTOR

Hackers used social engineering to trick internal employees into granting access to admin tools.

THE IMPACT

High-profile accounts (Musk, Obama) hijacked for a Bitcoin scam. Massive loss of platform trust.

GLOBAL CRISIS

YOUR PERSONAL DEFENSE SHIELD

PROACTIVE DEFENSE



THE 5-SECOND RULE

Pause before every click. Hover over links to verify the actual destination URL matches the text.



VERIFY OUT-OF-BAND

If a request is urgent or unusual, call the sender via a known, trusted number to confirm.



ENFORCE MFA

Multi-Factor Authentication is your strongest second line of defense against stolen credentials.

CRITICAL WARNINGS



DON'T TRUST DISPLAY NAMES

Attackers spoof names. Always check the actual email address behind the display name.



DON'T BYPASS SECURITY

Never disable security warnings or use personal email for company business transactions.



DON'T KEEP IT SECRET

If you clicked a suspicious link, report it to IT immediately. Silence only helps the attacker.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK 01

THE CEO REQUEST

You receive an urgent email from the "CEO" stating they are in a secret client meeting and need you to purchase \$500 in gift cards immediately.

RISKY ACTION

OPTION A

-  Buy them immediately to show initiative and impress the boss.

SECURE ACTION

OPTION B

-  Stop. Report the email and call the CEO's office via a known number to verify.

 **Why?** Real executives will never ask employees to purchase gift cards or bypass financial controls via email.

SCENARIO 02

THE SECURITY ALERT

You receive a system notification stating your corporate password has expired. The email provides a "convenient" link to reset it immediately.

SUSPICIOUS URL DETECTED

`https://micros0ft-update.com/reset`

Hovering over the link reveals the destination above.



Click the link and update your password quickly to ensure you aren't locked out of your workstation.



Recognize the "0" in Microsoft and the unofficial domain. Close the email and report it to IT Security.

RECOMMENDED ACTION

SECURITY IS A **SHARED** RESPONSIBILITY

Phishing is evolving, but your vigilance remains the
most powerful defense.

VIGILANCE IS THE PRICE OF SECURITY